



Phase 1:

Tasks and Responsibilities of a Theorist

Version 0.0

Goal: Achieve consensus on what we think theoretical psychologists (should) do/create

Output: Consensus list of core tasks/responsibilities of the theorists

Introductory note (v0.0)

Below is a list of tasks I think a theoretical psychologist could and should be responsible for. Not all theoretical psychologists should undertake all tasks at all times, and these are not necessarily the only tasks that could or should be undertaken. What is relevant is that these tasks are necessary – at least some theorists should work on them on occasion – and cannot be delegated completely to non-theorists – empirical psychologists, psychometricians, statisticians, software developers, etc.

The first version of this list of tasks/responsibilities and their descriptions reflects my personal considerations. It is based on:

- Two manuscripts I am writing at the moment: 1) on the need for modern theoretical psychology, and 2) on the need for theoretical psychology education in undergraduate and graduate psychology.
- Five years of experience teaching theory development to bachelor students.
- The statement [*The state and status of theory in psychological science*](#) (coauthored by 25 scientists, summarizing 65 sources)
- The many interactions I've had with experts from different fields over the last decade.

The origins of each of these core tasks/responsibilities could not be made explicit enough to reference particular literature in their descriptions. However, I don't think this should be considered a problem. This initial list only serves as the starting point, and the goal of this phase is not about what the literature says, but for you, the experts, to reach a consensus on what should be considered the core tasks/responsibilities of theoretical psychologists.



Core tasks of a (modern) theoretical psychologist

1. Identification and formation of explananda

The theorist identifies, categorizes, and orders the phenomena or capacities to be explained by theory. The theorist distinguishes robust phenomena that warrant explanation from raw data patterns and fleeting effects (e.g., potential false positives) that require further empirical research.

2. Developing and evaluating construct architecture

The theorist defines, differentiates, coordinates, and, where necessary, prunes constructs; builds ontologies and taxonomies; and specifies how theoretical terms refer to psychological phenomena, capacities, attributes, or processes.

3. Coordinating the relation between theory and measurement

The theorist specifies how constructs could, in principle, be detected, measured, or behaviorally evidenced; what counts as valid indicators; and what assumptions connect measures to theoretical entities.

4. Proposing, specifying, and connecting mechanisms

The theorist proposes and refines mechanisms, distinguishing sketches from more complete schemata and relating psychological explanations to neural, bodily, social, developmental, or environmental levels without reducing one level to another.

5. Constructing theories and their formal representations (models)

The theorist builds verbal theories and formal models (e.g., diagrammatic, computational, mathematical, etc.) that encode explanatory principles, clarify assumptions, and enable systematic comparison.

6. Exploring and repairing existing theories

The theorist extends theories, deepens them, resolves internal tensions, adds mechanisms, examines analogies, develops variants, and constructs how-possibly models when this improves coherence, richness, scope, or future testability.

7. Derivation, explanatory appraisal, scope mapping, and comparison

The theorist derives implications from theories and models, including explanations of established phenomena, observational predictions, intervention predictions, counterfactual expectations, and expected failures. The theorist identifies auxiliary assumptions, specifies boundary and scope conditions, compares rival theories, conducts anomaly analysis, evaluates how well theories account for existing evidence, and makes explicit what evidence should count for or against which version of a theory.



8. Integration, revision, and programme design

The theorist integrates fragmented empirical findings into coherent explanatory structures, evaluates whether existing theories can account for known phenomena, and revises, forks, merges, or discards theories in light of accumulated evidence. The theorist formulates theory-guided research programmes that organize future observational, experimental, interventional, formal, and measurement work. This includes articulating standards by which theories and models should be judged.